CONSUMER RISING

The Red List

10 ingredients to put back on the shelf — what they are, where they hide, and what the evidence actually says.

“Know what goes into your body.”

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How to use this in the store

Ten ingredients. That’s the whole list. You don’t need a chemistry degree — you need ten names and the discipline to put the package back.

1 **Learn the ten names**
Read through once. The “Look for” line on each page gives you the exact label words — including the aliases companies use.

2 **Check the last page first**
The put-back checklist on the final page is your pocket summary. Screenshot it or print it — it’s the whole Red List on one page.

3 **Put it back, don’t agonize**
See one of the ten? Put the product back and grab the alternative. Perfection isn’t the goal — fewer red-list items in the cart is.

4 **Let the scanner do the rest**
The free Consumer Rising label scanner checks all 53 watched ingredients automatically — these ten are simply the ones worth knowing by heart.

A note on honesty: every entry in this guide draws on Consumer Rising’s ingredient dossiers, each citing primary sources — FDA records, EFSA opinions, IARC classifications, peer-reviewed studies. Where the evidence is thin, we say so. That’s the point: you deserve the full picture, not a scare.

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Red 40

Look for on the label: Allura Red AC, E129, FD&C Red No. 40

WHERE IT HIDES

Candy, drinks, cereals, and snacks — anything bright red, orange, or pink.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

- In the EU, foods with this dye must warn they 'may have an adverse effect on activity and attention in children.'
- A 2007 study linked a mix of artificial colors to more hyperactivity in some children.
- Watchdog groups have petitioned the FDA for years to take a harder look at dyes.
- Look for 'Red 40', 'Allura Red', or 'E129' — brightest reds, oranges, and pinks are the usual suspects.

Bottom line: The most-used artificial dye in America — and the one with the most questions around it. Easy to spot, easy to skip.

Yellow 5

Look for on the label: Tartrazine, E102, FD&C Yellow No. 5

WHERE IT HIDES

Candy, sports drinks, flavored chips, instant noodles — and even some medicines.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

- EU requires the same 'activity and attention in children' warning label as other artificial colors.
- Included in the color mixes studied for links to hyperactivity in sensitive children.
- Hives from tartrazine are rare — but unlike most dyes, the FDA requires it to be listed by name on labels, so sensitive people can avoid it.
- Check candy, sports drinks, flavored chips, and instant noodles for 'Yellow 5' or 'Tartrazine'.

Bottom line: If a label says ‘Yellow 5’ or ‘tartrazine,’ you know exactly what you’re getting. That’s more transparency than most additives offer.

Yellow 6 (Sunset Yellow)

Look for on the label: Yellow 6, Sunset Yellow, Sunset Yellow FCF, FD&C Yellow No. 6, E110

WHERE IT HIDES

Orange sodas, cheesy snacks, candy, and baked goods.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

- CSPI describes Yellow 6 as the third-most-widely-used synthetic dye, found in beverages, candy, and baked goods.
- OEHHA's 2021 report — a two-year review of human and animal studies — found synthetic food dyes are associated with adverse neurobehavioral outcomes in some children, including inattentiveness, hyperactivity, and restlessness.
- The report found the FDA's intake limits rest on decades-old studies that were not designed to detect behavioral effects, and may not adequately protect children.
- CSPI rates all synthetic food dyes, including Yellow 6, Avoid.

Bottom line: California’s two-year review is the strongest evidence yet that these dyes aren’t as settled as regulators once said.

Red 3 (Erythrosine)

> **Look for on the label:** Red 3, Erythrosine, FD&C Red No. 3, Red No. 3, E127

WHERE IT HIDES

Cherry-red candy, cake icing, and baked goods.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

- The FDA revoked Red 3's authorization for food and ingested drugs in January 2025 under the Delaney Clause, a 1960 law that bars any color additive found to cause cancer in humans or animals.
- The trigger was a 2022 color-additive petition citing studies in which high doses of the dye caused thyroid tumors in male rats.
- The honest caveat, in the FDA's own words: the rat tumors came from a hormonal mechanism specific to male rats that does not occur in humans, and there is no evidence Red 3 causes cancer in people.
- Food manufacturers have until January 15, 2027 to reformulate; makers of ingested drugs have until January 18, 2028.

Bottom line: Banned going forward — but check labels until 2027, because it’s still on shelves today.

High Fructose Corn Syrup

> **Look for on the label:** HFCS, HFCS-55, Glucose-fructose syrup, Isoglucose

WHERE IT HIDES

Sodas first — then bread, ketchup, and salad dressing, where you'd never expect it.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

- About 55% fructose and 45% glucose — very close to table sugar, which is 50/50.
- The problem is total added sugar: high intake is linked to obesity, type 2 diabetes, and heart disease.
- One 12-ounce soda carries about 39 grams of sugar — more than a full day's limit for most adults.
- US use peaked around 1999 and has fallen as soda sales dropped.

Bottom line: Not poison — just the cheapest way to sell you more sugar than you meant to buy.

Partially Hydrogenated Oils

> **Look for on the label:** PHOs, Partially hydrogenated soybean oil, Shortening (some)

WHERE IT HIDES

Frosting, microwave popcorn, and commercial baked goods.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

- In 2015 the FDA ruled PHOs are no longer 'generally recognized as safe.'
- Trans fats raise LDL ('bad') cholesterol.
- Label trick: under 0.5g per serving can still be called '0g trans fat' — so '0g' is not always zero.
- Read ingredients for the words 'partially hydrogenated', especially in frosting, popcorn, and baked goods.

Bottom line: The label can legally say ‘0g trans fat’ while the ingredients say ‘partially hydrogenated.’ Trust the ingredients.

Brominated Vegetable Oil (BVO)

Look for on the label: BVO, E443

WHERE IT HIDES

Citrus sodas and sports drinks.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

- The FDA revoked BVO's food authorization in July 2024, concluding it was no longer considered safe after NIH-collaboration studies found potential adverse health effects.
- California's Food Safety Act (AB 418) also bans it in food from January 2027.
- Companies were given time to reformulate — check citrus sodas bought before the switch.
- Look for 'brominated vegetable oil' in citrus-flavored drinks.

Bottom line: Regulators already pulled it — if it’s still on the label, that product hasn’t been reformulated yet.

Potassium Bromate

> **Look for on the label:** Bromated flour, E924

WHERE IT HIDES

Bread, rolls, and flour — look for the words ‘bromated flour.’

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

- IARC classifies it Group 2B ('possibly carcinogenic to humans') based on sufficient evidence in animals.
- California bans it in food from January 2027 under the California Food Safety Act (AB 418).
- Most of it breaks down during baking, but residues can remain.
- Look for 'potassium bromate' or 'bromated flour' on bread and roll labels.

Bottom line: Banned in European food years ago and flagged by California. Worth choosing otherwise.

Sodium Nitrite & Sodium Nitrate

Look for on the label: Sodium Nitrite, Sodium Nitrate, E250, E251, E249 (Potassium Nitrite), E252 (Potassium Nitrate), celery powder, celery juice powder, cultured celery juice

WHERE IT HIDES

Bacon, hot dogs, and deli meat — including ‘uncured’ meats made with celery powder.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

- In the stomach's acid environment, nitrite can react with amines and amides from meat protein to form N-nitroso compounds, some of which are known carcinogens.
- IARC classified ingested nitrate and nitrite, under conditions that result in endogenous nitrosation, as probably carcinogenic to humans (Group 2A).
- Nitrites and nitrates sit at number one on EWG's Dirty Dozen list of food additives, which cites their probable-carcinogen classification when ingested.
- The label trick to know: meats cured with celery powder are still cured — the nitrite molecule is identical regardless of source, and USDA rules require the 'uncured' label on them.

Bottom line: A genuine trade-off: a real food-safety job against a real long-term question. And ‘uncured’ doesn’t mean nitrite-free.

TBHQ (Tertiary Butylhydroquinone)

> **Look for on the label:** TBHQ, tertiary butylhydroquinone, tert-butylhydroquinone, t-butylhydroquinone, E319

WHERE IT HIDES

Crackers, potato chips, and oil-heavy baked goods.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SAYS

- CSPI rates TBHQ 'avoid' in its Chemical Cuisine guide because of its cancer risk.
- EWG calls it an ingredient of concern and suggests limiting it: multiple animal studies tie it to immune dysfunction, including weaker natural-killer-cell and flu responses.
- EWG's own 2021 peer-reviewed study found TBHQ may act as an immunotoxin, affecting receptors that regulate inflammation and immune responses.
- Regulators approved it decades ago — the FDA in 1972, the EU in 2004 — but the EU still won't allow it in infant formula over safety concerns for babies.

Bottom line: Approved decades ago and barely studied in humans since. Here, the absence of evidence is the evidence.

The put-back checklist

The whole Red List on one page. Screenshot this — or print it and keep it in your wallet.

INGREDIENT	WORDS TO LOOK FOR ON THE LABEL
Red 40	Allura Red AC, E129, FD&C Red No. 40
Yellow 5	Tartrazine, E102, FD&C Yellow No. 5
Yellow 6 (Sunset Yellow)	Yellow 6, Sunset Yellow, Sunset Yellow FCF, FD&C Yellow No. 6
Red 3 (Erythrosine)	Red 3, Erythrosine, FD&C Red No. 3, Red No. 3
High Fructose Corn Syrup	HFCS, HFCS-55, Glucose-fructose syrup, Isoglucose
Partially Hydrogenated Oils	PHOs, Partially hydrogenated soybean oil, Shortening (some)
Brominated Vegetable Oil (BVO)	BVO, E443
Potassium Bromate	Bromated flour, E924
Sodium Nitrite & Sodium Nitrate	Sodium Nitrite, Sodium Nitrate, E250, E251
TBHQ (Tertiary Butylhydroquinone)	TBHQ, tertiary butylhydroquinone, tert-butylhydroquinone, t-butylhydroquinone

Sources & method

Every entry is drawn from Consumer Rising's ingredient dossiers at consumerrising.com/ingredients, each citing its primary sources: FDA color-additive and GRAS records, EFSA scientific opinions, IARC Monographs classifications, and peer-reviewed studies (all linked from the dossiers). Concern levels reflect our editorial judgment — they are not medical advice, and an "Avoid" rating is not a claim that a normal serving will harm you. Dossiers are reviewed and updated as the science moves; check the site for the latest.

"Know what goes into your body."